# FOREWORD

*Muhammad Yunus*

One of the fundamental challenges for a democracy is to work out how to ensure the voice of the majority does not trample the essential rights of minorities. Even as we applaud and rejoice in the new freedoms enjoyed by the people of Myanmar, the country's government must face this challenge as it evolves from autocratic rule into a democratic state. The tragedy of the Rohingya people, which continues to unfold in Rakhine State in the country's western corner, on the border with Bangladesh, will be its testing ground.

The rejection of citizenship rights for Rohingyas, denial of freedom of movement, eviction campaigns, violence against Rohingya women, forced labour, expulsion from their lands and property, violence and torture have made Myanmar's ethnic Rohingyas the most persecuted minority in the world. I humbly add my voice to the simple demand of the Rohingya people: that their rights as our fellow human beings be respected, that they be granted the right to live peacefully and without fear in the land of their parents, and without persecution on grounds of their ethnicity or their form of worship. A government must in the end be judged by how it protects the most vulnerable people in its society, and its generosity towards the weakest and most powerless. Let not the good work of this government be overshadowed by the continuing persecution of the Rohingya people.

I urge the government of Myanmar to end all kinds of persecution and discrimination against the Rohingyas or any other ethnic and religious minorities. In addition, the international community needs to take a proactive role to end the ongoing isolation and persecution of the stateless Rohingya people. To end human rights violations not just in Myanmar but also around the world, the commitment of all stakeholders, including the